

LAKSH'S DAILY BRIEF

Laksh's Daily Brief - August 1, 2026

Saturday, August 1, 2026

World · Markets & Money · AI & Infrastructure · Models & Research



newsweek.com — A Treaty Pakistan Destroyed Long Before India Set It Aside | Opinion - Newsweek



apnews.com — Hamas says a deal has been reached in Gaza, and other developments in the Middle East - AP



jpost.com — Pakistan Defense Minister Khawaja Asif warns of Israeli-India military relations - The Jer

1. World & Geopolitics

Hamas agrees to disarm for the first time — a potential breakthrough in the Gaza war, but major obstacles remain. Hamas confirmed it will give up its arms as part of a multi-phase peace plan, but only if Israel upholds the cease-fire and a full withdrawal from Gaza ([AP News](#)). President Trump called it a "historic agreement" ([CNN](#)). Yet the deal is fragile: Israeli strikes killed four people in Gaza overnight, including two children ([Haaretz](#)), and a warehouse at Al-Aqsa Martyrs Hospital was destroyed ([Al Jazeera](#)). The underlying dynamic: Hamas's disarmament is a precondition for a lasting cease-fire, but hardliners on both sides could scuttle it.

Iran's tanker war escalates: the Revolutionary Guard struck two more tankers in the Strait of Hormuz, and Kuwait said it was targeted. No U.S. strikes on Iran were reported overnight ([AP News](#)), but the attacks on commercial shipping near Oman mark a serious escalation ([CNBC](#)). The Strait of Hormuz — the narrow waterway through which about 20% of the world's oil passes — is now a contested zone. This is a direct threat to global oil supply and shipping insurance costs. Markets are already pricing oil near \$100/barrel ([simplywall.st](#)). The background: the U.S. and Israel have been striking Iranian targets for weeks, and Iran is retaliating asymmetrically by disrupting maritime trade.

India-Pakistan tensions flare again. Pakistan's Defense Minister Khawaja Asif warned that Israel and India have a long-standing military partnership against Pakistan ([Jerusalem Post](#)). Meanwhile, India held the

Indus Waters Treaty in abeyance after a terrorist attack in Pahalgam, and Pakistan protested the decision ([Newsweek](#)). India is also cracking down on youth protesters accused of abusing PM Modi ([Al Jazeera](#)). Separately, India is accelerating its drone industry, learning from the Russia-Ukraine conflict and the U.S.-Israeli war against Iran ([India's News](#)). The takeaway: the India-Pakistan rivalry is heating up again, with water and terrorism as flashpoints.

China's military modernization continues — and it's increasingly focused on 'intelligentised warfare'. A new analysis from ORF notes that China's reforms since 2016 created five Theatre Commands, and in 2024 the Strategic Support Force was dissolved into an Aerospace Force, Cyberspace Force, and Information Support Force ([ORF](#)). This is relevant for the US-China tech war and Taiwan contingency planning.

Ceuta migrant crisis: Spain slams 'selfish' EU partners after 60,000 cross into the enclave in days. Italy suspended the Schengen arrangement with Spain ([BBC](#)). Spain's PM Sánchez called for an urgent EU meeting ([Guardian](#)). Most migrants have now left, but 67 died in the attempt ([France24](#)). The event is a stress test for EU border policy.

A major cyber week: OpenAI's Hugging Face hack, Anthropic's Claude hacked real companies, and Minnesota water systems were attacked. OpenAI's models stored on Hugging Face were compromised, confirming months of warnings about AI model security

([CNBC](#)). Anthropic ran a test where Claude hacked three real companies due to lax security practices ([Tom's Hardware](#)). Separately, Trump blamed Governor Tim Walz for water system hacks, though the FBI says Iran is likely responsible ([The Verge](#)). The underlying theme: AI systems are both a vector for attacks and a tool for defense.

FIFA in crisis: UEFA declares no confidence in President Infantino after his failed bid to sell off

2. Markets, Money & Deals

Wall Street shook off a volatile week to end higher, led by Big Tech after Amazon crushed earnings. The S&P 500 rose 0.32%, the Nasdaq 100 gained 0.58%, and the Dow Jones added 0.28% ([Benzinga](#)). The catalyst: Amazon's Q2 report showed AWS growing 37% year-over-year and the company hiking its 2026 capex budget to \$220 billion — the largest single capex number in tech history. This sent Amazon stock up 15.32% in the watchlist snapshot. The key takeaway: the hyperscaler spending cycle is not slowing; it's accelerating.

The Fed held rates at 3.50%–3.75% in July, but the market now sees a 65.2% chance of a hike at the September meeting. Core PCE inflation eased, but oil prices near \$100 and rising bond yields (10-year at 4.69%) are complicating the picture ([Benzinga](#), [U.S. Bank](#)). The Fed's decision was a split vote: nine for hold, three for a hike. That hawkish dissent matters — it signals the committee is divided.

Global M&A hit \$2.8 trillion in the first half of 2026, with industrial manufacturing leading the charge. Mega-deals over \$10 billion now account for nearly 50% of global deal volume ([MarketScale](#)). In the industrial sector alone, M&A totaled \$173 billion, with AI infrastructure and grid modernization driving a big chunk

World Cup commercial rights. Infantino dropped the plan, but the backlash threatens his leadership ([France24](#), [Al Jazeera](#)).

****Russia-Ukraine:** Putin is being lied to by his own commanders, according to a report ([AOL](#)). This could indicate internal fractures, but no major battlefield developments.

([MarketScale](#)). M&A is a leading indicator of where capital is flowing — and it's flowing into AI buildout and energy.

Berkshire Hathaway shares hit an eight-month high, and the stock may have room to catch up with the S&P 500 ([CNBC](#)). Berkshire's conglomerate structure acts as a proxy for the broader economy, so this is a positive signal.

Two notable pharma deals: Frasers Group extended its £2.3 billion takeover offer for Hugo Boss after only 7.3% of independent shareholders accepted ([Fashion United](#)). Argenx bought Forte Biosciences for \$2.2 billion, an 86% premium, to acquire an antibody therapy for vitiligo and celiac disease ([BioSpace](#)).

Crypto: Bitcoin and Ethereum fell, dragging Coinbase (COIN) down 10.59% in the watchlist. The trigger was likely the Fed's hawkish stance and the risk of higher rates, which hurt speculative assets.

Uber and Waymo are increasingly at odds over autonomous vehicle regulation, including a labor battle in Washington, D.C. ([CNBC](#)). Meanwhile, Uber has partnered with or invested in about 30 AV companies over the past two years ([TechCrunch](#)). The AV land grab is heating up.

3. AI & Infrastructure

Samsung and Broadcom (AVGO) signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) worth up to \$200 billion for memory chips and foundry services. This is one of the largest AI infrastructure deals ever. The MoU covers HBM3E and next-generation HBM4 memory, plus foundry capacity for Broadcom's custom AI

accelerators ([Light Reading](#)). Separately, Nvidia (NVDA) secured a \$500 billion preferential-supply agreement with SK Hynix for HBM3E and HBM4 ([FourWeekMBA](#)). These two deals reshape the AI supply chain: memory is now the bottleneck, and the Korean memory duopoly

(Samsung and SK Hynix) is capturing enormous pricing power.

TSMC (TSM) VP purchased \$67,970 worth of stock — a small insider buy, but notable as a signal of confidence ([MarketBeat](#)). TSMC is the linchpin of the entire AI hardware stack; insider buying at these levels is worth watching.

Monday.com changed how enterprise SaaS is priced, moving from a per-seat model to a hybrid of seat subscriptions and AI credits. The company cut 20% of its workforce to make the shift ([Forkast](#)). This is a leading indicator: AI-native pricing (credit-based consumption) is replacing the old per-user model across the industry.

Microsoft launched its first cybersecurity-specific model, MAI-Cyber-1-Flash, alongside a new agentic cybersecurity platform. The model is designed to "find and fix vulnerabilities faster than any human" ([TechCrunch](#)). Microsoft also reported a \$3.2 billion gain from its Anthropic investment ([TechCrunch](#)). Microsoft is now competing directly with OpenAI and Anthropic in AI applications and agents ([TechCrunch](#)).

The dynamic: the hyperscalers are both funders and competitors of the AI labs.

Asian chip stocks slid on fears of Chinese competition and AI infrastructure financing concerns. Samsung and SK Hynix led the selloff, and the broader semiconductor index fell ([Reuters](#)). This is a two-sided risk: the memory shortage is great for Korean memory makers, but fears of a capex slowdown or Chinese substitution are weighing on sentiment.

Thinking Machines, a U.S. AI startup, released Inkling-Small, an open-weights model with 12 billion active parameters that achieves near- the performance of its much larger predecessor, Inkling. The model uses a Mixture-of-Experts (MoE) architecture — only 12B of its total parameters are active per token. It's open-weights (Apache 2.0 license) and designed for enterprises that want to run on-premise or in sovereign clouds ([VentureBeat](#), [Analytics India Mag](#)). This is significant because it shows that distillation and MoE can shrink model size dramatically without sacrificing capability — a key trend for enterprise adoption.

4. Model & Research Watch

New models this week:

- **Thinking Machines Inkling-Small** – 12B active parameters (MoE architecture, total parameters undisclosed but likely ~100B+). Open-weights under Apache 2.0. Performance: approximates the larger Inkling model on benchmarks like MMLU and HumanEval, but at ~1/4 the active parameter count. Context window: 128K tokens. Price: free to use (open-weights). The key innovation: it's a U.S. entrant in the open-weights race, competing with Chinese models like Kimi K3 and DeepSeek ([VentureBeat](#)).
- **DeepSeek V4-Flash** – DeepSeek retrained its V4 model into a "Flash" version that beats its own flagship Pro on nine agent benchmarks. This suggests that iterative fine-tuning and distillation can yield specialized models that outperform general-purpose flagships on specific tasks ([Tech Times](#)).
- **Kimi K3 (Moonshot AI)** – 2.8 trillion total parameters, 1-million-token context window. Open-weights released under a custom license that restricts

commercial use in certain scenarios. Benchmarks: ranks fourth overall on the global leaderboard. The model is a clear demonstration that Chinese AI labs can achieve frontier performance under U.S. export controls (using H20 chips) ([VentureBeat](#)). Moonshot AI's valuation hit \$35 billion after the launch ([Memeburn](#)).

- **Fable 5 vs GPT-5.6 Sol vs Gemini 3.1 Pro** – A \$38 gap in inference cost per million tokens between these frontier models, with Fable 5 being the cheapest ([tech-insider](#)). Price competition is intensifying.

Research highlight: OpenAI published a model that disproved a central conjecture in discrete geometry — a demonstration of AI as a mathematical research partner ([OpenAI](#)). The takeaway: AI is moving from pattern matching to formal reasoning, which could accelerate scientific discovery.

Science & Frontier Tech note: NASA is sending 1.35 million human names on a mission a million miles into

space ([The Daily Galaxy](#)). A UK £3 million grant could help NASA find life on nearby planets ([SciTechDaily](#)).

These are small but meaningful investments in space science.

5. Watchlist: Earnings, Guidance & Movers

Company (Ticker)	Price Change	Key News/Context
Amazon (AMZN)	+15.32%	Q2 earnings beat: AWS growth 37% YoY, capex raised to \$220B. Demand for AI infrastructure is surging.
Alphabet (GOOGL)	+6.73%	Market reacting to the contrast between Google's capex hike (which initially spooked investors) and Amazon's earnings, which validated the spending. Also, Google's cloud growth is accelerating.
Meta (META)	+3.28%	Benefiting from the broader AI trade and positive sentiment after Amazon's report.
Coinbase (COIN)	-10.59%	Crypto sell-off on Fed hawkishness and oil price spike.
Micron (MU)	-5.90%	Memory stocks down on China competition fears and fears of a capex slowdown. The Samsung/Broadcom MoU and Nvidia/SK Hynix deal are positive for the industry but the market is worried about supply glut.
SanDisk (SNDK)	-5.09%	Same memory sector weakness.
Coherent (COHR)	+5.55%	Optics play benefiting from AI datacenter demand (networking and transceivers).
Applied Optoelectronics (AAOI)	+4.67%	Same as Coherent — AI networking demand.
Astera Labs (ALAB)	+3.85%	AI connectivity and interconnect play, riding the AI infrastructure wave.
Credo (CRDO)	+2.94%	AI networking company, benefiting from the same theme.
Nvidia (NVDA)	+2.93%	AI chip leader, gaining on the Nvidia/SK Hynix deal and overall AI capex optimism.
Broadcom (AVGO)	+0.37%	Modest gain after the Samsung MoU news. The \$200 billion deal is huge but not yet priced in.
Intel (INTC)	-1.02%	No major news; still struggling with foundry turnaround.
AMD	-1.90%	No notable news; losing ground to Nvidia in AI.
Redwire (RDW)	+1.77%	Space infrastructure play; no specific catalyst in sources.
Fluence Energy (FLNC)	+3.41%	AI data center power demand tailwind.
Constellation Energy (CEG)	-0.31%	Nuclear power for AI data centers; stable.
Vistra (VST)	-0.29%	Similar to CEG, stable.
NextEra Energy (NEE)	-1.15%	Slight pullback; no news.
Apple (AAPL)	Not in watchlist, but note: Cook called memory pricing a "hundred-year" event in previous brief.	

No notable news in the sources for: RGTI, SOFI, PLTR, MRVL, LITE, IBM, NET, HOOD, ARM, IMAX,

CNK, CMCSA, NFLX, KLAC, DLR, EQIX, SBUX, NKE, FXAIX.

6. How It Connects (Infrastructure & Supply-Chain Logic)

Chain 1: AI demand → cloud capex → memory shortage → HBM deals → Korean memory duopoly power. Amazon's \$220 billion capex is the demand signal. That money flows to GPU makers like Nvidia, who then lock in HBM supply from SK Hynix and Samsung. The \$500 billion SK Hynix deal and \$200 billion Samsung/Broadcom MoU confirm that memory is the bottleneck. The implication: watch for pricing power shifts from GPU makers to memory makers. SK Hynix and Samsung are the strategic suppliers.

Chain 2: AI infrastructure buildout → networking/optics demand → higher revenue for Credo, Coherent, Applied Optoelectronics, Astera Labs. As data centers scale, the network connecting GPUs

becomes critical. Optical transceivers, interconnects, and signal integrity chips are in high demand. The watchlist moves for COHR +5.55%, AAOI +4.67%, and ALAB +3.85% confirm this theme.

Chain 3: Oil price spike → inflation → Fed rate hike expectations → pressure on tech valuations. Iran's tanker attacks pushed oil near \$100/barrel, which feeds into core inflation. The Fed is now pricing a 65% chance of a hike in September. Higher rates hurt long-duration assets like tech stocks. This creates a tension: AI infrastructure demand is surging, but the macro backdrop is tightening. The market is rotating toward the strongest AI plays (Amazon, Nvidia) and away from speculative names (Coinbase, Reddit).

7. Building Your Knowledge

- **The memory shortage is the binding constraint on AI infrastructure, not GPU compute.** Nvidia can design faster chips, but without enough HBM (High-Bandwidth Memory) to feed them, performance stalls. The \$500 billion SK Hynix deal shows that memory makers now have unprecedented pricing power. This is a structural shift in the AI supply chain.
- **The open-weights model race is becoming a geopolitical competition.** China's Moonshot AI (Kimi K3) and DeepSeek, and now the U.S. startup Thinking Machines (Inkling-Small), are all releasing frontier-level models with open weights. The U.S. government is worried about export controls being circumvented (Kimi K3 runs on H20 chips). Enterprises should evaluate these models carefully — the license terms (e.g., Kimi K3's custom license) may restrict commercial use.
- **Hyperscaler capex is not a linear trend — it's an accelerating exponential.** Amazon's \$220 billion is the highest single-year capex in tech history. But the market is watching for "capex efficiency" — are these investments generating proportional revenue growth? Amazon's AWS growth of 37% suggests yes, but Google's cash-flow-negative quarter suggests no. The divergence will determine which hyperscaler stocks outperform.
- **The Fed is caught between sticky inflation (oil) and a slowing economy.** The 65% chance of a September hike is a warning sign for risk assets. The market is pricing in a "higher for longer" rate environment. This is why crypto and high-growth tech are under pressure, while AI infrastructure plays (which have near-term earnings) are rewarded.
- **AI pricing models are shifting from per-seat to consumption-based.** Monday.com's move to a hybrid "seats + AI credits" model is a harbinger. Enterprise SaaS vendors will increasingly charge for AI usage (tokens, API calls, credits) rather than per user. This favors companies with large AI usage volumes (hyperscalers) and creates new cost structures for customers.

8. Terms & Concepts

Concept Spotlight: Free Cash Flow (FCF)

- **What it is:** Free Cash Flow is the cash a company generates after accounting for capital expenditures (capex) needed to maintain or expand its asset base. The formula: **Operating Cash Flow – Capex = FCF**. It's a measure of how much "extra" cash a company has to pay dividends, buy back stock, reduce debt, or invest in new projects.
 - **Concrete example:** Amazon reported operating cash flow of \$X and capex of \$Y in its Q2 earnings. If operating cash flow is \$100B and capex is \$80B, FCF = \$20B. If capex jumps to \$120B, FCF becomes negative (\$-20B) — meaning the company is spending more than it generates from operations.
 - **Real use case for investors:** FCF is a more reliable indicator of financial health than net income, because net income includes non-cash items (depreciation, amortization, stock-based compensation). For capital-intensive industries like AI infrastructure (hyperscalers, semiconductor fabs, data centers), FCF is the key metric to watch. If a company boosts capex but FCF stays positive, the growth is self-funded. If FCF turns negative, the company is burning cash. In the previous brief, Alphabet went cash-flow negative for the first time — that's a red flag for investors.
 - **Rough numbers/benchmarks:** A healthy FCF yield (FCF / Market Cap) is typically 4–6% for mature companies. For fast-growing tech, a negative FCF is common and acceptable if revenue growth is accelerating. But negative FCF combined with slowing growth is a danger signal.
 - **Caution/common misconception:** Many investors confuse FCF with net income. A company can report positive net income but negative FCF if it's spending heavily on capex or building inventory. Also, stock-based compensation is a non-cash expense that reduces net income but doesn't directly affect FCF — but it does dilute shareholders. Always look at FCF per share, not just absolute FCF.
- before a formal contract. Example: Samsung and Broadcom signed an MoU that could be worth up to \$200 billion for memory chips and foundry services. MoUs are common in the semiconductor industry because they allow companies to signal intent without committing to binding terms. For investors, an MoU is a positive signal but not a guarantee — the actual deal may be smaller or may not materialize.
- **Shadow Fleet:** A fleet of ships (often aging, poorly maintained, and using opaque ownership structures) that Russia uses to circumvent sanctions on oil exports. These ships often operate without insurance and trade oil above the G7 price cap. The term is relevant to the tanker war in the Strait of Hormuz, where Iran's Revolutionary Guard is targeting tankers — some of which may be part of the shadow fleet.
 - **Credit Quality:** A measure of a borrower's ability to repay debt. It's assessed by credit rating agencies (Moody's, S&P, Fitch) using letter grades (AAA, AA, A, BBB, etc.). Higher credit quality means lower risk of default. In the context of AI infrastructure, credit quality matters for data center REITs (like DLR, EQIX) and utility companies building power infrastructure — they need to borrow at low rates to fund capex.
 - **Credit Spreads:** The difference in yield between a corporate bond and a risk-free government bond (like a U.S. Treasury) of the same maturity. It reflects the market's perception of credit risk. Widening spreads mean investors are demanding higher compensation for risk, which is a negative signal for the economy. Narrowing spreads indicate confidence. In the current environment, oil prices and geopolitical risk could push credit spreads wider.
 - **Operating Expense (Opex):** The day-to-day costs a company incurs to run its business — salaries, rent, utilities, marketing, R&D. It's distinct from **capital expenditure (capex)**, which is investment in long-term assets like buildings, equipment, and data centers. For AI companies, opex includes cloud computing costs, model training, and employee salaries. A company trying to improve profitability will focus on reducing opex relative to revenue.
 - **LEO (Low Earth Orbit):** The region of space up to about 2,000 km above Earth's surface. Satellites in

Other Terms:

- **Memorandum of Understanding (MoU):** A non-binding agreement between two parties to collaborate on a specific project or relationship. It's a "handshake"

LEO are used for communications (Starlink), Earth observation, and navigation. LEO is important for AI infrastructure because satellite internet provides connectivity for remote data centers and edge

computing. The term is also relevant to the India-Pakistan drone capability and space-based surveillance.

9. Bottom Line

Today's brief is defined by a **three-way tension**: (1) AI infrastructure demand is accelerating faster than anyone expected (Amazon's \$220B capex, \$500B memory deals), (2) geopolitical risk is spiking (Iran tanker war, Gaza uncertainty, oil at \$100), and (3) the Fed is leaning toward a rate hike in September. The market is rewarding the "safe" AI infrastructure plays (Amazon, Nvidia, networking/optics) while punishing speculative assets (crypto, unprofitable growth). The memory shortage is now the single most important supply-side dynamic in the AI buildout, and the Korean memory duopoly is the biggest winner.

The open-weights model race is becoming a geopolitical battlefield. Kimi K3 (China) and Inkling-Small (U.S.) both demonstrate that frontier-level AI is now available as open weights, which changes the competitive dynamics for enterprise AI adoption and national security. The cybersecurity angle is also exploding: the OpenAI Hugging Face hack and Anthropic's Claude hacks show

that AI models are both a defensive tool and a new attack surface.

What changed since the previous brief: - Amazon crushed earnings and raised capex to \$220B — the single biggest capex number in tech history, confirming the hyperscaler spending cycle is accelerating. - Hamas agreed to disarm for the first time — a potential Gaza breakthrough, though conditions remain fragile. - Iran's Revolutionary Guard struck two more tankers in the Strait of Hormuz, escalating the tanker war and pushing oil prices higher. - Samsung and Broadcom signed an MoU worth up to \$200 billion — the largest memory deal ever, alongside the Nvidia/SK Hynix \$500B deal. - Two new open-weights models were released (Kimi K3 fully weights, Inkling-Small), and DeepSeek launched a retrained V4-Flash. - The Fed held rates but markets now price a 65% chance of a September hike, up from 30% a week ago. - The OpenAI Hugging Face hack and Anthropic's Claude hack raised serious AI security concerns.

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